



AIR TRAVEL

Air travel was once a luxury that few could afford, but in the 1970s cheaper air fares and the introduction of wide-body aircraft made long-distance travel possible for millions of people. Airlines carry a lot of lightweight cargo too, especially mail and perishable goods such as fruit and flowers. Smaller aircraft also provide regional transportation, which can be vital in large, sparsely populated countries such as Australia and Canada.

► TIME MACHINES

Jet aircraft have slashed the time it takes to travel vast distances, making the world seem smaller.

ROAD NETWORKS

Before the internal combustion engine was invented, road transportation moved at the speed of a horse. Now multilane highways link major cities and are connected to local roads that give access to even the smallest, most remote settlements. Road networks are vital for local travel, but also for the delivery of food, fuel, and other supplies.



URBAN TRANSPORTATION

The major cities of the world could barely function without rapid transit systems that allow millions of people to move around quickly and efficiently—on buses, streetcars, local trains, and subway networks such as this one in Chengdu, China.

HIGH-SPEED RAIL

Railroads were the first high-speed transportation system. Today, modern electrified rail networks achieve speeds that cannot be matched on the road. Railroads are expensive to build, but once they are up and running they are more efficient than any other form of land transportation.

► BULLET TRAIN

The Shinkansen train can streak through the Japanese landscape at 186 mph (300 km/h).

